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BENGAL'S STRICKEN TEA-GROWING AREAS



₹5,000 CRORE
Estimated size of West Bengal's tea industry

₹11.30 PER KG
Drop in auction prices for CTC tea in W. Bengal in 2023, compared with 2022

340,635
No. of workers directly employed in West Bengal's tea industry

1 MILLION KG
Drop in exports of Bengal and Assam tea in 2023 (Jan. to July) as compared with the corresponding period in 2022

A DEPRESSED MARKET

Manufacturers sell tea through auction centres at different places in India as well as outside its ambit. According to a recent study by ITA, the oldest association of Indian tea producers, for the 2023-24 fiscal, there has been a decline of Rs 12.49 per kg in Assam and of Rs 11.30 per kg in West Bengal in the auction prices of crush-tear-curl (CTC) or dust tea in the organised sector. The auction prices for orthodox tea—loose tea leaves—have declined by Rs 95 a kg. Compared with the cheaper CTC, orthodox tea is considered to be of superior quality, with subtler flavours. It is usually harvested and processed by hand. CTC, on the other hand, is machine-processed, is fully oxidised and has a very dark colour.